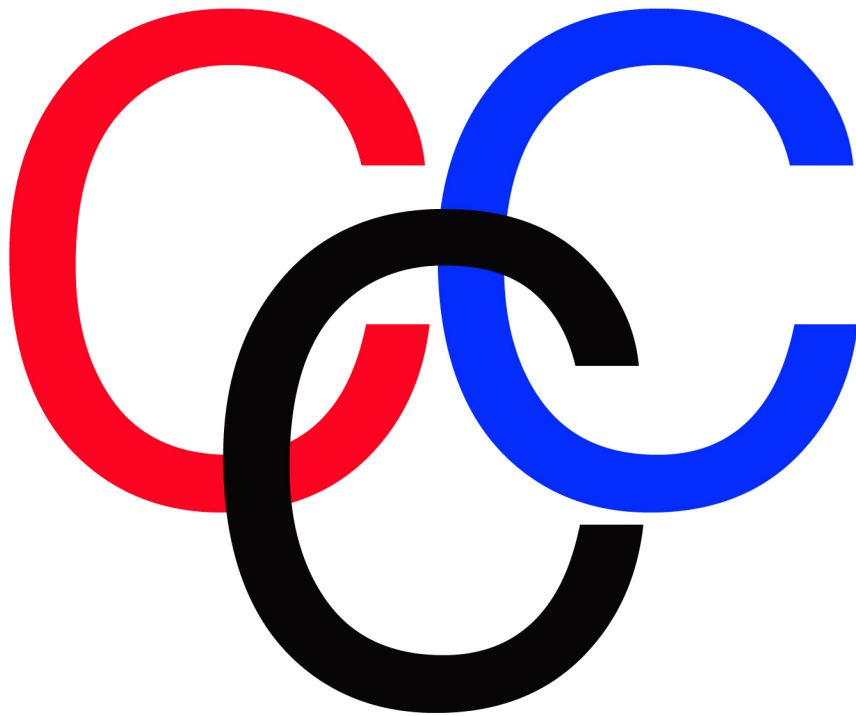




CRISIS CONTROL CENTER
USER MANUAL

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INTRODUCTION

Dear Volunteer _____,
(Your Name Here)

Your contribution as a volunteer at the Crisis Control Center is an integral part in our ability to help callers with their crises. This Volunteer Manual will ensure that you can appropriately deal with callers and successfully offer advice that will ensure a timely end to their respective crisis.

Following this user manual closely will result in the best crisis management solutions we have to offer. All the answers are laid out for you here. As long as you follow the guide, you'll be solving the crises of the world in no time.

Thank you again from your team here at the Crisis Control Center!

Yours Truly,

The Crisis Control Center Team at



INSTRUCTIONS ON THE USE OF THIS MANUAL

While answering phone calls for the Crisis Control Center, it is important that you follow the structure of this manual carefully. Things to be said directly to the caller will be in **RED**, while other information necessary for your interaction will be in black. Please follow along with the **RED** text carefully while answering calls. The general instructions and important information will appear on the left side, while the specific instructions and lines appear on the right. This allows you to process the information in each section before choosing which lines are appropriate for the caller. Each section covers a different stage of the phone conversation, so be sure to start from Step 1 on page 4.

STEP 1: ANSWER THE CALL

At the Crisis Control Center, we want our callers to have the best experience possible while we solve their crisis. Please be polite and respectful at all times, and ensure that the tone of your voice is appropriately pleasant.

Because each crisis is different, sorting out the characteristics of the crisis before going into the details is very important. This means that the caller should not tell you the crisis outright. You need to get the pertinent information first. Be very stern on this point, as it is the only way to ensure that you come to the crisis from the correct standpoint.

STEP 1: ANSWER THE CALL (LINES)

Hello, Crisis Control Center. This is _____.
(state your name)

Allow the caller to acknowledge this greeting, but quickly continue into the following introduction.

Today I plan to solve your crisis, but first I need to tell you a bit about the process we use here at the Crisis Control Center. It is important that I am able to categorize your crisis without knowing the full details to begin with. While this sounds counterintuitive, it allows me to assess your crisis in a strategic manner. I will ask you a series of questions about your particular crisis, and then I will be able to better deal with the crisis at hand. Is this acceptable?

Allow the caller to agree to this method. If they disagree, reiterate the importance of the process we use here at the Crisis Control Center.

Once they have agreed move onto step 2.

STEP 2: DETERMINE THE NATURE OF THE CRISIS

Our callers might be seeking advice for a wide variety of crises. It is important that you are able to differentiate for the caller which type of crisis they are having. Also, by understanding the types of crises you might be dealing with, you will be better equipped to determine the advice necessary to solve the caller's crisis later on in the call.

2A: Personal Crisis

A personal crisis is one that only involves the caller. This might include things like being depressed or losing the house keys. However, this does not include technological/medical crises, as they have a distinct category of their own.

2B: Interpersonal Crisis

An interpersonal crisis involves at least one other person besides the caller. This might include anything from infidelity in a relationship to a fight with a friend over which movie to go and see this weekend. This category does not include large societal issues, as they have a distinct category of their own.

2C: Social/Societal Crisis

A social/societal crisis is one that involves culture at large. This might include problems that the caller is experiencing that are related to culture in their origin (i.e. anxiety, depression, homelessness), but it might also include problems that the caller is particularly anxious about that are not related to them specifically (i.e. global warming, the extinction of endangered species, war).

2D: Technological/Medical Crisis

A technological/medical crisis is one that involves technology or any sort of medical issue. This could include the loss of a cell phone, being addicted to the Internet, finding out about a fatal illness, or even getting a paper cut.

2E: Other Crisis

This category is reserved for the rare instance that the caller's crisis does not fall within the categories listed above.

STEP 2: DETERMINE THE NATURE OF THE CRISIS (LINES)

What is the nature of your crisis? Is it personal, interpersonal, social/societal, technological/medical, or other?

Allow the caller to respond with their answer. If they say they are not sure, offer to define these categories for them.

I can define these categories for you, if that would be helpful.

If they ask for the categories to be defined, read these descriptions to assist them in identifying the type of crisis they are dealing with.

A personal crisis is one that involves only you.

An interpersonal crisis involves you and at least one other person, but does not include issues with society in general.

A social/societal crisis is one that involves culture at large.

A technological/medical crisis is one that involves technology or medicine in any way. If your crisis could fall into this category or another, this is the overriding characteristic, and therefore your crisis should be categorized as technological/medical.

Other crisis is a category reserved for the rare instances where your crisis does not fit into another category. It is best if you can determine another category other than this one for your crisis to fit into, as it is exceptionally rare that your crisis actually falls outside of the categories previously mentioned.

Allow the caller time to decide which category their crisis fits into. If they still cannot decide, read the categories and their descriptions to them again. Their crisis must be categorized in order to continue. Assist them in determining the nature of their crisis. This might mean that you suggest one in order to continue on, based on the structure listed on page 6.

Once the nature of the crisis is determined, move onto step 3.

STEP 3: DETERMINE THE SEVERITY OF THE CRISIS

Our callers will have varying extremes in the severity of their crises. It is important to determine the level of severity in order to help them through their crisis. This does not mean that less severe crises are disregarded or taken less seriously; all crises are important to those in them. However, it is possible to assess the level in which a crisis is affecting the life of the caller. This is how the severity is assessed, not on the external assessment of Crisis Control Center volunteers – you. Please keep this in mind.

3A: Critical/Severe Crisis

A critical/severe crisis is one that the caller believes will destroy their life if it is not solved. They are desperate to solve it at any cost.

3B: High Level Crisis

A high level crisis is one that the caller is extremely distressed about. This type of crisis might appear to be quite similar to a critical/severe crisis, but there is an additional degree of extreme desperation present in a critical/severe crisis which is absent in this category.

3C: Medium Level Crisis

A medium level crisis is a huge inconvenience or annoyance in the caller's life, but it is not nearly as severe as the critical/severe crisis or the high level crisis.

3D: Low Level/Minimal Crisis

A low level/minimal crisis is an annoyance to the caller, but only that, an annoyance.

3E: Cosmetic Crisis

A cosmetic crisis is very rare in this context, but you might come across one. This type of crisis is hardly a crisis. It is basically an excuse for the caller to complain. The issue itself does not really bother them; it is more of a means to an end – getting someone to listen to them. It is fairly uncommon for such individuals to call us here at the Crisis Control Center, but it is important to be aware of the possibility of this type of crisis. If you do encounter a cosmetic crisis, remember that it is no less important than any other type of crisis.

STEP 3: DETERMINE THE SEVERITY OF THE CRISIS (LINES)

Next we need to determine the severity of your crisis. Would you categorize your crisis as critical/severe, high, medium, low/minimal, or cosmetic?

Allow the caller to respond with their answer. If they say they are not sure, offer to define these categories for them.

I can define these categories for you, if that would be helpful.

If they ask for the categories to be defined, read these descriptions to assist them in identifying the severity of the crisis they are dealing with.

A critical/severe crisis is one that involves life-altering consequences.

A high level crisis is one that is distressing, but not life-altering. It has severe consequences, but it will not ruin your life.

A medium level crisis is a great inconvenience or annoyance, but not nearly as severe as a critical/severe crisis or a high level crisis.

A low level crisis is one that is frustrating to you, but not severe in any way.

A cosmetic crisis is one that seems annoying, but is actually more of an anecdote to make conversation than a real crisis.

Allow the caller time to decide the true severity of their crisis. If they still cannot decide, read the categories and their descriptions to them again. Their crisis must be categorized in order to continue. Assist them in determining the severity of their crisis. This might mean that you suggest one in order to continue on, based on the structure listed on page 8.

Once the severity of the crisis is determined, move onto step 4.

STEP 4: DETERMINE THE DURATION OF THE CRISIS

Each crisis has a specific duration. This duration relates to the true length of the crisis, not the time in which the caller has been aware of the crisis. For example, an alcoholic should not consider their crisis recent just because they have only now become aware of their issue; it is likely something that they have been struggling with for years. Likewise, a person realizing that they have forgotten a deadline for something that needs to be finished tomorrow should not classify their issue as momentary if the real issue is that they are perpetually forgetting things, or they are constantly missing deadlines.

4A: Lifelong Crisis

A lifelong crisis is one that has been plaguing the caller for their whole life, or at least a substantial part of their life. This type of crisis is often masked by what seems to be smaller, recent crises. However, if the underlying cause is lifelong, then the specific crisis should be categorized as lifelong. For example, if the caller's crisis is about sabotaging a relationship they were recently involved in, but they have been doing this their entire life, the crisis would be lifelong.

4B: Long-Term Crisis

A long-term crisis is one that has been persisting for at least a year.

4C: Recent Crisis

A recent crisis is one that has been an issue for less than six months, but at least a month.

4D: Momentary Crisis

A momentary crisis is one that has come about in the last week or less.

As you have probably noticed, there are gaps in between these categories. Any crisis that falls within the gaps is one that could be categorized in either group it is between. The previous categories (from Steps 2 and 3) can be used in assisting the completion of this step. For example, if it is severe crisis that has been going on for three weeks, it would likely be categorized as a recent crisis instead of a momentary one. However, if it is a low level crisis that has been going on for three weeks, it might alternately be categorized as a momentary crisis.

STEP 4: DETERMINE THE DURATION OF THE CRISIS (LINES)

What is the duration of your crisis? Is it lifelong, long-term, recent, or momentary?

Allow the caller to respond with their answer. If they say they are not sure, offer to define these categories for them.

I can define these categories for you, if that would be helpful.

If they ask for the categories to be defined, read these descriptions to assist them in identifying the duration of the crisis they are dealing with.

A *lifelong crisis* is one that has been an issue for your whole life, or at least a majority of your life. Smaller crises might actually fall into this category if they are symptomatic of a larger issue that is lifelong.

A *long-term crisis* is one that has been an issue for at least a year.

A *recent crisis* is one that is a more current problem in your life. This type of crisis usually falls within the spectrum of one month to six months.

A *momentary crisis* is one that has only come about very recently – sometime within the last week.

If your crisis falls between two categories, I can assist you in determining the best category for your crisis.

If the caller's crisis falls between two categories and they need assistance determining which durational category to place their crisis in, take into consideration the severity of their crisis and then place it into whichever category seems most appropriate. Their crisis must be categorized in order to continue.

Once the severity of the crisis is determined, move onto step 5.

STEP 5: DETERMINE THE ATTITUDE OF THE CALLER

The attitude of the caller is an important indicator of the advice the caller is seeking. A distressed caller is clearly looking for different advice than a calm caller. Two individuals might be calling about the exact same crisis, but their attitude indicates differences in their personality, and therefore affects the kind of advice that they are seeking and will appreciate.

5A: Distressed Caller

A distressed caller is exactly what it sounds like – a person who sounds distressed. This could be subtle things like tone of voice or more overt things like actual statements suggesting distress. However, it is likely that a distressed caller will exhibit both of these telling symptoms of distress.

5B: Calm Caller

A calm caller exhibits none of the above symptoms and seems willing to wait patiently for your assistance.

STEP 5: DETERMINE THE ATTITUDE OF THE CALLER (LINES)

How do you currently feel about your general attitude in relation to this crisis? Do you feel distressed or calm?

If the caller claims to be calm but you can tell that they are distressed, feel free to categorize the caller as distressed. Alternately, if the caller sounds calm, but claims to be distressed, you should always categorize them as a distressed caller.

If distressed:

I am so sorry that you feel that way. Soon I will have enough information to offer you advice, and your stress about the situation will be relieved.

If calm:

It is a relief to hear that you feel calm about your crisis. Soon I will have enough information to offer you advice, and you will be able to deal with your crisis and move on.

Continue to step 6.

STEP 6: RELATE EMOTIONALLY TO THE CALLER

Being able to connect emotionally with the caller is important. Their ability to trust your advice later on is largely based on this component. It is important for us at the Crisis Control Center that each caller feels safe, understood, and well cared for. Relating emotionally with the caller is an important part of making this a successful call.

6A: Validate the concerns of the caller

Validating the concerns of the caller is a necessary step. Even if you do not feel that the caller's concerns should be validated, it is important for the caller to believe that you do. You will not be able to relate to each caller, but you should appear to.

6B: Commiserate with the caller

This step is easier for some individuals than others. Share an experience about a crisis of your own with the caller to show that you have gone through something equally terrible and that you know how they feel. It is important for you to remember that the caller should feel that they can trust you with the details of their crisis later on. This step shows that you are both trustworthy and willing to share. It encourages the caller to be more forthcoming with the details involved in their own crisis.

STEP 6: RELATE EMOTIONALLY TO THE CALLER (LINES)

I know that this must be difficult for you. I have had crises in my life that have been just as difficult, and I made it through them. You will make it through this crisis too. I'd like to share a similar crisis of my own with you now.

Offer details about a specific crisis you have gone through at some point in your life. It is important to remember that the more the caller can relate to you, the more they will be willing to listen to your advice later on.

(Offer the details of a specific crisis you worked through in your own life.)

Continue to step 7.

STEP 7: ASK THE CALLER TO DISCLOSE FURTHER DETAILS

This is the part where you ask the caller to disclose any other important details about their specific crisis. They might choose to tell you the story of their crisis. This is okay – it is important that they talk through the issue they are dealing with in as much detail as they feel necessary. Do not act surprised by the caller's crisis for any reason. Whether the crisis does not seem to match up with the information gathered earlier on, or the crisis seems silly, outrageous, or unacceptable to you in some way, you must maintain your professionalism and foster the nonjudgmental environment we encourage at the Crisis Control Center.

STEP 7: ASK THE CALLER TO DISCLOSE FURTHER DETAILS (LINES)

At this point, are there any other details about your crisis you would like to share with me? Knowing the specifics of your crisis helps me to be able to offer you the most appropriate advice to solve your crisis today.

Allow the caller time to disclose any information they wish to tell you regarding their crisis. Listen attentively. Feel free to add in comments to make sure the caller knows you are listening.

Thank you for sharing these details with me. I can see that your crisis is important to you and that solving it will make things better for you.

Continue to step 8.

STEP 8: RESOLVE THE CRISIS

At this point, you understand the basic components of the caller's crisis, and you know the specifics of the issue they are dealing with. Step 8A is meant to allow you to recount the specific information gathered in Steps 2-5 and relate it to the newly gathered details given to you in Step 7. Step 8B lists advice you can give to the caller to solve their crisis. Please choose only one.

8A: Make a final analysis of the crisis

Remind yourself of the nature, severity, and duration of the crisis. Also remind yourself of the attitude of the caller.

8B: Give the most appropriate advice

In relation to the specifics of the caller's crisis, pick one of the following suggestions that you feel would be helpful in dealing with their problem.

- I. Follow your gut.**
- II. Smile. Change your attitude. It really can help.**
- III. Leave the problem for a while and see if it goes away on its own.**
- IV. Ask for forgiveness, and deal with the consequences.**
- V. Acknowledge that this is a common crisis.**
- VI. Remember that tomorrow is a new day.**
- VII. You know what you need to do. Just do it.**
- VIII. Tell someone you trust, and ask for help from those you love.**
- IX. Cut caffeine and sugar out of your life. Take care of yourself.**
- X. Give into your stress for a while. Stress can be motivating.**

STEP 8: RESOLVE THE CRISIS (LINES)

After carefully considering the categories that your crisis falls into, and the specific details you shared with me about your crisis, I am able to offer you some advice.

At this point find the **ONE** corresponding piece of advice, from the list on page 18, that you feel is most appropriate for the caller.

I. Follow your gut.

Your gut instincts are often the best indicator of what you should do in a given situation. Also, you will be happier with a decision if you follow your gut than if you overanalyze your choice of action.

II. Smile. Change your attitude. It really can help.

Smiling more can change a bad situation into a bearable one. Sometimes, it can even change your attitude. It might show you that your crisis isn't a crisis after all, but rather that it is an opportunity to see things differently and do something new.

III. Leave the problem for a while to see if it goes away on its own.

The common cold usually goes away with time. Some crises are the same. Wait it out.

IV. Ask for forgiveness, and deal with the consequences.

Sometimes a crisis is not a crisis, but a mistake we've made. When this is the case, you should take responsibility for your actions and move on.

V. Acknowledge that this is a common crisis.

Sometimes things are the way they are, and they are that way for a lot of people. But at least you are not alone.

Continued on page 21.

STEP 8: RESOLVE THE CRISIS – CONTINUED

Each option of advice has been carefully thought through. Please consider just as carefully which advice is the most appropriate for the caller you are dealing with. While the advice might seem generic, there is a lot that can be gained from simple straightforward advice. Remember that wisdom and intelligence are not the same thing. Simple solutions and advice can, and usually do, hold the most wisdom.

STEP 8: RESOLVE THE CRISIS (LINES) – CONTINUED

VI. Remember that tomorrow is a new day.

Even if things are rough now, they can turn around in the future. Each day has the possibility of a new situation.

VII. You know what you need to do. Just do it.

It is actually pretty simple. You need to do something, you just do not want to. You know you have to, so you might as well get the job done.

VIII. Tell someone you trust, and ask for help from those you love.

It sounds like this is not a problem you can deal with on your own. Talk to those around you. Even if they do not know the answer, they can listen.

IX. Cut caffeine and sugar out of your life. Take care of yourself.

It sounds silly, but slowing down, eating better, and remembering that you need to take care of yourself can make lots of life's problems disappear.

X. Give into your stress for a while. Stress can be motivating.

Some crises are necessary to move forward. They motivate change. Let the stress of the situation take over and see if it forces you to change your circumstances.

Continue to step 9.

STEP 9: ENCOURAGE THE ACCEPTANCE OF THE ADVICE

It is important that the caller actually accept the advice you have offered them. The process that we use here at the Crisis Control Center allows for the best possible understanding of their crisis, and the advice offered is an important component in dealing with their problem. Encourage the caller to take the advice and use it.

STEP 9: ENCOURAGE THE ACCEPTANCE OF THE ADVICE (LINES)

I hope that the advice that I have offered is helpful to you. Even if you don't see its relevance now, I hope that eventually you can see that it has a crucial role in the resolution of your crisis. Remember, sometimes the best advice we get in life is the advice we most readily reject.

Continue to step 10.

STEP 10: THANK THE CALLER/END THE PHONE CALL

Politely ending the phone conversation leaves the caller with the impression that their call was important. They should be left with the most optimistic attitude you can offer. Your optimism will show them that they should be optimistic as well, and that they should be pleased with the results of the Crisis Control Center process.

STEP 10: THANK THE CALLER/END THE PHONE CALL (LINES)

Thank you so much for calling the Crisis Control Center today for advice about your crisis. It was my pleasure to help you, and I hope that after taking the advice I've offered you, you'll see that with time your crisis will be resolved to your advantage.

I do hope that things turn out alright for you, and that your crisis can be resolved quickly and efficiently by implementing the advice you've been given here at the Crisis Control Center.

Do feel free to call again with any other crisis you might have in the future!

Goodbye.

Hang up the phone.

That is the end of the Crisis Control Center process. With time, these calls with get easier, and you will be able to deal with crises more efficiently.



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